WHERE I COME FROM

FIRST SERIES

BY: DIVINE BESONG EYA

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INTRODUCTION

I have a narrative to share, one that resembles a series or possibly a book, centered around my origins. Numerous thoughts and hopes have traversed my mind regarding this tale. My upbringing was not in a location that could be deemed marketable or brimming with remarkable features, nor could it be classified as urban, advanced, or technological by today's standards. Urban areas are typically well-organized and meticulously planned; however, I believe there was a significant reason for my beginnings. This is precisely why I feel compelled to share my story with you today. Perhaps, in some way, my experiences resonate with yours, be it through shared geographical features, feelings of confinement, degradation, or the sense of being an outcast. If you ventured to the city for shopping, maybe you were ridiculed and labeled as a bush man or woman, made to feel unwelcome. There are many motivations behind my desire to convey this story to you, as it represents a journey I would love to unfold in a series of episodes. However, I believe what I am about to share transcends the format in which I present it.

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CHAPTER ONE

LACK OF ACCESS

CHAPTER ONE: LACK OF ACCESS

I was raised in a community that lacked many of the essentials that people in urban areas often take for granted. Basic necessities such as accessible roads, reliable electricity, clean drinking water, and quality education were sorely missing from our lives. We navigated footpaths to reach local markets, where we purchased essential provisions like clothing, farming tools, and other necessities. Despite our scarcity of material goods, we had each other, which provided a sense of connection and support. However, it became increasingly clear to me that we were merely surviving rather than truly living. Our existence felt disconnected from the broader world; we were in the same nation and perhaps even the same region, yet we belonged to an entirely different class.

The only means through which we could access information from the outside world was via radio signals. I distinctly remember my father's small battery-operated radio, which he would tune to FM frequencies 98.2 and 97.4. Occasionally, we could pick up signals from our neighboring country, Nigeria, which opened a small window to the outside world. This radio was a lifeline, connecting us to music, news, and stories beyond our immediate environment. The melodies and rhythms from the 90s still resonate in my memory, a testament to the power of music to transcend boundaries and transport us, even in our isolated circumstances.

In my community, luxuries were virtually nonexistent. Good food was limited to our local agricultural produce, and our sources of light came from lanterns, which we affectionately referred to as "bush lamps." Quality educational institutions were a rarity, with our local primary schools constructed from mud, known locally as "mart houses." The roads we traversed were mere footpaths, and reaching local markets required crossing rivers and streams, often leading to perilous journeys where lives were lost in the struggle to procure basic goods before market closures. These challenges highlighted the stark reality we faced and underscored the lengths we were willing to go just to secure our livelihoods.

For those without relatives to accompany them on these arduous journeys, life felt even more perilous. The absence of vibrant young men and women to share the burden of travel often stirred feelings of jealousy and, at times, even led to witchcraft among community members. This envy was not born from a desire to harm but rather from the harsh realities of life that had chosen their paths for them. The struggles we faced were a collective experience, binding us together in ways that sometimes manifested in unexpected ways.

02

CHAPTER TWO

SUBJECTED TO BELEIVE IN LITTLE

CHAPER TWO: SUBJECTED TO BELEIVE IN LITTLE

We confronted numerous challenges and difficulties throughout our lives. The patterns of rejection and hardship ignited a belief within me that I was destined for something greater. I came to see this journey as a divine purpose, one that compels me to reignite dreams within my people, my community, and my nation. I aspire to awaken every dreamer who feels as though they were mistakenly placed in an environment that stifles their potential.

Having grown up in such an environment, I have experienced two distinct generations—the 90s and the 21st century. The resilience I developed from traveling long distances, sometimes for days on end to access local markets, has shaped my character. My journeys, including those to Nigeria, have instilled in me a sense of consistency and determination. The physical toll of these travels often left my feet and joints swollen, but it was all for the purpose of sharing my story with you.

My parents would often soothe my swollen limbs with ointments to alleviate the pain, yet this struggle never deterred me from dreaming about who I wanted to become. In my community, there was an unspoken rule against aspiring for something different or better; those who dared to think beyond their current circumstances often faced harsh criticism. This was not due to any prohibition, but rather a product of a mindset conditioned to accept only what was visible each day.

In my community, many have resigned themselves to their fates, while others still cling to a sliver of hope. A few individuals send their children off to obtain college degrees in search of a brighter future. Yet, my inquisitive nature drove me to question our roots and existence, often causing friction with those around me. My most pressing question was, "Why the forest?" I wondered why there were no roads or infrastructure, and it wasn't until I witnessed more developed mountainous cities in Africa and Europe that I began to understand the disparity between my upbringing and the possibilities that existed elsewhere.

03

CHAPTER THREE

WE GIVE MORE THAN WE GET

CHAPTER THREE: WE GIVE MORE THAN WE GET

Our main agricultural products included cocoa, yams, palm oil, and plantain, yet we possessed a natural resource—timber—that could elevate our living standards significantly. However, since late 90s, timber has been extracted from our lands without regard for the local inhabitants, leaving us to continue our lives on foot. We still relied on makeshift timber boats to cross rivers, just as our parents did in the 60s. This reality paints a vivid picture of where I come from-Ogurang village, in the southwest region of Cameroon.

For years, I grappled with questions surrounding my existence and the stark contrast between those living in abject poverty, using lanterns for light, while others thrived in comfort with advanced technology. The first time my people encountered a vehicle was during the timber exploitation operations destined for France. Despite our produce reaching Europe, we continued to walk on foot, realizing deep down that we deserved more. I became aware that our circumstances were not permanent and that we were capable of achieving greater things.

This upbringing has profoundly influenced my life, shaping me into a resilient individual who refuses to settle for mediocrity. My community forged a person who understands that everyone experiences their own seasons of challenges, yet creating something meaningful from nothing is a privilege reserved for a select few. To anyone out there who shares a similar background, whether it be from a forest, village, farmhouse, or rural area, this book is for you.

Reflecting on the times when severe weather conditions would lead to flooding, damaging our mud homes and radios—the only sources of information from the outside world—brings back memories of struggle. There were moments when rivers would swell, making it impossible for us to transport goods across. Yet, through it all, I challenge the dreamers: your origins are not your enemy; rather, they are your compass and motivation, guiding you toward your destiny.

I have friends who often express their reluctance to ever return to our village or community. However, I remind them that our homeland is the very foundation of our existence. The burdens I carried, like the extra kilograms of cocoa on my head that strained my neck, were not in vain; they were part of my journey to share this story with you.

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CHAPTER FOUR

CALL FOR ACTION

CHAPTER FOUR: THE CALL FOR ACTION

My community does not define my potential or my future; rather, it offers clarity regarding the uniqueness of my vision. There is a significant reason for my circumstances and the time in which I was born. My origins reveal not only my identity but also my capacity to lead or follow.

The place we come from reveals our true nature—whether it be good or bad. However, what truly matters is the action we take from this point forward. These actions may be accompanied by fear of failure or uncertainty about making the right choices.

Questions about what might happen if I fail or if I am wrong have plagued me for years. I have spent countless moments paralyzed by inaction, unsure of how to initiate change or believe in the divine intentions for my life. I have faced setbacks and given up more times than I can count, yet this does not diminish our call to greatness. Our origins are our strength, originality, and, ultimately, our identity.

Perhaps I am the worst at this, feeling as though I was never raised to be anything other than ordinary. Maybe my purpose was merely to exist and pass on my lineage, or perhaps I was simply meant to follow trends and patterns. Yet, I am constantly reminded by an inner voice that urges me not to settle for less, for there is a reason I was created.

There is a reason I was placed in this particular community during this time. This is the reason I share my voice with you through this book—the time for action is now. You may find yourself in a place where you feel unrecognized or misunderstood, where your accent does not align with the so-called modernity.

You may come from a background that differs greatly from those raised in the city. Regardless of where we originate, there exists an undeniable impact and influence that shapes our lives. No matter your doubts, the experiences you have had and the path you have walked will provide answers to your struggles now and in the future, guiding you toward your destiny.

Thanks for reading

follow me to the next episode of "where I come from" and this time, be accompanied by someone, a friend or a relative.

WHERE I COME FROM

And so, as this series closes, we are left not with an ending — but with an awakening. The journey we have taken together is more than a story. It is a mirror. A reminder that our roots run deeper than we were told, that our identity carries power, and that our history is not lost — only waiting to be rediscovered. Every revelation has peeled back a layer of silence. Every truth uncovered has reignited a flame. But this is only the beginning. There is more to uncover. More to remember. More to reclaim. The next series will go even deeper — beyond the surface of what we think we know — into the powerful, hidden, and undeniable truths of **where we come from**. Prepare your heart. Prepare your mind. The journey continues.
Written with purpose and conviction,

BY: DIVINE BESONG EYA
Join me in the next series of Revealing Where We Come From* — because our story is far from over.